> Subsequently we heard that scarcely any of these poor wretches escaped from this defile: and that driven to the extreme of hunger they had sustained life by feeding upon their dead comrades.[61]

Only eighty survivors from the column managed to make it alive over the Jagdalak holly-oak barrier on the night of 12 January.

Most of these – some twenty officers and forty-five privates of Shelton's 44th Foot, and a couple of artillerymen and sepoys – were exposed and surrounded at dawn as they stood, uncertain of the correct road, at the top of the hill of Gandamak, ten miles further on. Overwhelmingly outnumbered – 'every hut had poured forth its inhabitants to murder and plunder' – and with only twenty muskets and two rounds of ammunition each between them, the troops decided to make their last stand. They were offered quarter but refused. Many felt their regiment had been disgraced after running away from the hilltop of Bibi Mahru on the evening of 23 November, and now they were determined to die fighting and so redeem the regimental honour. They formed a square, and defended themselves, 'driving the Affghans several times down the hill' until they had exhausted the last of their rounds, and then fought on with their bayonets.[62] Then, one by one, they were slaughtered.[ii] The Afghans took only nine prisoners. One of these was Captain Thomas Souter, who wrapped the regimental colours of the 44th around his waist and was taken captive by the Ghilzai who assumed that someone so colourfully dressed must be worth holding to ransom. 'Thinking I was some great man from looking so flash,' he wrote, 'I was seized by two fellows after my sword dropped from my hand by a severe cut on the shoulder, and my pistol missing fire. They hurried me from this spot to a distance, took my clothes off me, except my trousers and cap, and led me away to a village.'[63]

Fifteen more cavalrymen made it as far as Fattehabad, where ten were killed while sitting down to accept breakfast from some villagers. Four were shot down from the rooftops as they attempted to remount and ride out of the village. One more – Eldred Pottinger's young nephew Thomas – was tracked down, caught and beheaded hiding amid the beautiful cypress trees and water runnels of Shah Jahan's Nimla Gardens, where Shuja had first been defeated and lost his throne in 1809.

Only one man made it beyond this point. Dr Brydon was still fifteen miles from the safety of Jalalabad. 'I proceeded alone,' he wrote later.